★ Recipe No. 03 ★

Classic Cinnamon Rolls

12 rolls. Science!

Two food scientists. Twelve fluffy rolls.

1–2 h + 30–60 min rising | 20–25 min bake at 350 °F | 12 rolls

The good stuff

Cups + spoons · Metric

The dough

unbleached bread flour 568 g · + more for rolling	4 cups
granulated sugar 65 g	⅓ cup
instant dry yeast 11 g	3 tsp
fine table salt 10 g · kosher: weigh 10 g (about 2 tsp)	1¼ tsp
egg 1 · room temperature	1 large
liquid oil 24 g · vegetable, canola, sunflower or olive	2 tbsp
milk 300 ml · whole or 2%	1¼ cups
unsalted butter 28 g · softened	2 tbsp
water 10–20 ml · a splash at a time	as needed

The wet-sand filling

dark brown sugar 220 g · packed	1 cup
ground cinnamon 10 g	4 tsp
all-purpose flour 13 g	1½ tbsp
water 22 ml	1½ tbsp
fine table salt 1.5 g · added for unsalted butter	¼ tsp
unsalted butter 70 g · half-melted, stirred to finish	5 tbsp

The icing

cream cheese 113 g · softened	4 oz
unsalted butter 28 g · softened	2 tbsp
powdered sugar 90 g	¾ cup
pure vanilla extract ½ tsp	½ tsp

Feathery, pull-apart rolls with a wet-sand filling that stays put. Just technique.

Unsalted swap.
She uses salted butter; this sheet uses unsalted, plus ¼ tsp salt in the filling. Her flour cup is heavy: 4 cups = 568 g.

Metal pan, no cream bath.
Cream bath = mushy rolls; glass needs 5–10 min extra. Tacky dough? Add water, never flour. Overnight: shape, cover, chill, then proof.

Method →

Recipe: Christina Marsigliese / Scientifically Sweet

Amounts: as published, cups + grams are the author's own

The BEST Classic Cinnamon Rolls

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Let's make a mess.

Stand mixer + dough hook, greased 13 × 9-in metal pan, rolling pin, offset spatula, thermometer.

1 Dry stuff in little piles.

Put the flour in the mixer bowl. Add sugar, yeast and salt in separate little piles on top.

→ *Salt not touching the yeast.*

2 Knead it like you mean it.

Add egg, oil, milk and soft butter. Hook on medium-low, 10–15 min; scrape down after 2 min, then every 3–5. Dry or stiff? Add water, 10 ml at a time.

→ *Climbs the hook, then pulls off the bowl; 24–26 °C (75–79 °F).*

3 Stretch + fold.

Stretch and fold on a lightly floured counter until very smooth. Tuck into a ball, oil lightly, cover in a bowl.

→ *The ball's skin pulls smooth without tearing.*

4 Big rise, quick chill.

Rise somewhere warm for 1–2 hours, then chill 15 min (skip in a very cold kitchen).

→ *Nearly tripled in size.*

5 Pan + wet-sand filling.

Grease the pan. Mix sugar, cinnamon, flour and salt. Melt butter only halfway, stir till melted, then stir it in with the water.

→ *Wet-sand sludge: not hot (oils out), not cold (sets up).*

6 Roll, spread, strip, spiral.

No more kneading. Roll to 17 × 14 in, long side facing you; spread filling to the edges. Cut 12 strips (~1¼ × 14 in), roll each into a spiral (or roll a log, slice 12).

→ *Squared-off rectangle, 12 even strips.*

7 Proof shoulder to shoulder.

Spiral side up, snug, no overlaps. Cover loosely, proof 30–60 min. Preheat to 350 °F / 177 °C.

→ *A poke springs back slowly with a slight imprint. Deep dent = over-proofed.*

8 Bake to temp.

Bake 20–25 min. Tent with foil if the tops brown too fast. Cool on a rack 15–20 min.

→ *Evenly golden; center roll at 92–94 °C (198–201 °F).*

9 Ice it.

Beat cream cheese and butter very smooth, then powdered sugar and vanilla. Spread thin over each roll.

→ *Smooth, thick and creamy.*

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